

Playback

In the file support department, none could compare with the iPods. Both the iPods support AAC, MP3, MP3 VBR, Apple Lossless, WAV, AIFF, Audible formats. The only player that could come close to them was the Samsung YH-J70 which supports MP3, WAV, WMA, OGG file formats. The other players including the iRiver were regular run of the mill players and supported only MP3, WMA, and in some cases, WAV playback.

Battery Type

The iRiver H10 was a player that featured a removable Li-ion battery, which comes bundled with the player. Removable Li-ion battery packs are available for the iRiver H10 which can be purchased separately.

Another player that had the same feature was the Creative NOMAD Jukebox Zen Xtra—though removing the battery requires you to take off the front cover of the player.

All other players featured regular internal Li-ion batteries.

Extras

The Samsung YH-J70 was the most feature packed of all. Although it has a smaller screen, this player ups the ante when it comes to features. Yes, SRS WOW is right here along with a host of other presets that enhance your listening experience. Not satisfied with the presets, then make your own custom equaliser. This feature of custom equaliser was available on most players, except the iPod.

This Samsung also has a game feature for those boring times when you want to listen to music and do something else as well—you can also play video, view photos and read text files on this player. However, the earphones left a lot to be desired, and a better pair would be a welcome addition for this player. This player can also act as a USB host, which lets you connect specific models of digital cameras directly to the player and transfer images to it.

Jargon Buster

SRS WOW: WOW is a state-of-the-art technology from SRS (Sound Retrieval System) Labs that uses special algorithms to improve the quality, dynamics, spatial experience and bass tone of digitally compressed audio files. In effect, WOW helps even small speaker systems including PC speakers and television deliver audio with richer bass and an enhanced 3D spatial experience.

Audio Codecs (MP3, WMA, AAC, etc.): An audio codec is a computer program that compresses or decompresses digital audio data so that the file size of the audio data reduces to a fraction of that of the original raw data. There are a variety of audio Codecs available such as MP3, WMA, AAC, FLAC, etc. Codecs can be lossy, like MP3 which results in a loss of detail in the audio quality but a higher compression ratio or lossless, like FLAC, results in faithful reproduction of audio but are not exactly 'high-compression'.

Audio encoding: Audio encoding is the process of analysing the information in an audio file and rearranging it in a format that has been predefined by a Codec.

Bitrate: This is the number of bits of data transmitted per unit time. It is usually expressed in bits per second or bps. The higher the bitrate, the more the information transmitted and the higher the fidelity of the audio.

Compression ratio: Compression ratio of an audio file is the ratio of the file size of the encoded audio file to the file size of the same audio data in raw form.

The iRiver H10 was the only player in the whole comparison, which bundled a premium Sennhieser MX400 pair of earphones with the player as a part of the package. This was another player that had support for displaying text files and photos. No other player in the HDD-based portable players comparison could match up to these two in terms of features.

Ergonomics And Ease Of Use

The interface of the Samsung YH-J70, again, is similar to its younger sibling and very intuitive. Button placement is excellent and everything is easily accessible for one handed operation. This is one surefire iPod killer from the Samsung stables!

The interface of the iRiver is clean and uncluttered although the buttons are a little less responsive as compared to the Samsung, Creative or iPod players. Again, this device needed to be used with the proprietary iRiver Plus software for transferring music to the device.

However, if you connect this device without installing the software, it still shows up as a removable drive and you can transfer data, which includes music that can be played back. But this transferred music is not categorised under various headings such as Artist, Title etc. which happens when you use the proprietary software to transfer music. Playlist support is present using both software and on-the-fly transfers and you can create custom playlists in the player.

The Apple iPod and the iPod Mini were identical in terms of usability, and the ease of use that is a trademark of Apple devices. The feather touch response of the buttons on these devices makes them a dream to use.

These devices, too, were dependent on the iTunes software for being able transfer music to the device. This whole concept of making portable device software dependent is advantageous



The Samsung YH-J70 has motion sensors to prevent shocks